

Yatra was a true testament to the Government's commitment to the welfare of the fishing community and coastal development.

3. Journey sails into Maharashtra - Phase-3 of Sagar Parikrama

The third phase of the *Yatra*, which ran from February 19th to 21st, 2023, covered the northern parts of Maharashtra. The journey began in Surat, Gujarat, on February 19th, where the Union Minister Shri Parshottam Rupala, briefed representatives of the press and media about the importance of the fisheries sector and the objectives of *Sagar Parikrama Yatra*.

The Minister then proceeded to Hazira Port, where he started the journey onboard the Coast Guard Ship 'Varaha' with officers of the Department of Fisheries, NFDB and fishermen representatives. The inaugural function of Phase-3 took place at Satpati Village, in the Palghar district of Maharashtra, on 20th February, 2023. Nearly 1000 people participated in the event, including stakeholders, Minister (Fisheries) of Maharashtra State, ex-governor, MPs, MLAs, and fishermen leaders. Cultural events were also organized, depicting the indigenous Koli-Agri Fishermen tradition of Maharashtra state. The entire program was live-streamed by NFDB on its social media platforms.

During the interaction of the Union Minister with the fishermen, various issues were flagged, such as the need for strengthening and modernization of existing Fishing Jetty at Satpati and the creation of Fish Landing Centre, modern fish market with post-harvest and cold-storage facilities, providing fish drying platform, initiatives for fisher-women engaged in marketing of fish, strengthening of fishers cooperative societies, implementation of ban on usage of LED light fishing etc. Subsequently, the visit to Vasai, in the Palghar district of Maharashtra, on February 20th, was attended by nearly 5,000 people. Cultural events depicting the tradition of Maharashtra state were also performed by the fishers and local people. During the program at Vasai, fishermen were felicitated, who saved the lives of policemen of the Palghar Police Motor Parivahan Department due to sinking of police boat. Certificates were distributed to beneficiaries covering various schemes.

In the last leg of Phase-3 of *Sagar Parikrama* on 21st February 2023 the Union Minister along with other Ministers from Union and State Government, MPs and MLAs, attended a series of programs including visit of the Fishing harbours at Versova, Bhaucha Dhakka, and Sassoon Dock in Mumbai and sub urban areas, and interacted with fishermen community at all these locations. Certificates and sanctions were also distributed to the beneficiaries covering various schemes from the stage such as loans under the Kishan Credit Card (KCC) Scheme and subsidies under PMMSY. The Yatra program was a huge success in Maharshtra, with more than 20,000 people present physically and attended these events. Fishermen were so happy to receive the Union Minister Sh. Parshottam Rupala at their doorstep and cordially welcomed him out at sea with their *Dhol & Nagadas*. The interaction programs were also live-streamed on various social media platforms such as YouTube and Facebook.

With the Sagar Parikrama *Yatra*, the Union Minister, Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying has successfully raised awareness among coastal communities and fishermen, directly connecting with them at their doorstep to understand their issues and suggestions. This initiative brought the government representatives including senior officers to remote and marginalized areas that have never before received such attention. The senior officials of the Coast Guard have also actively participated in the Yatra, and created awareness amongst the fishermen about 'safety at sea'. Coast Guard also appreciated the important role played by fishermen being the 'eyes and ears' in supporting coastal security of the nation.

The *Sagar Parikrama Yatra* has not only been well received by the fishermen and coastal communities, but also helped the Department of Fisheries, Government of India and State Fisheries Departments to better understand the ground-level challenges faced by the fishermen and to improve scheme implementation. By listening and learning, the government is better equipped to devise policies that will improve the quality of life and economic well-being of the coastal community, especially marine fishermen across the country.





